

Interface Requirements for Automated Docketing and Filing in a Modernized CM/ECF

A practitioner's perspective for the case-management modernization program

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ECFiler — File with confidence. File with code you can read.

1. Who this is from, and why

I am a docketing specialist at a national law firm. My work is the layer between attorneys and CM/ECF: preparing filings, selecting events, tracking NEFs, and reconciling dockets across dozens of districts, daily and at volume. I also build software against the Judiciary's documented public interfaces (the PACER Authentication API and Case Locator API), so I see both what the systems promise and what integrators actually do to work around their gaps.

This paper describes what professional filing operations need from the interfaces of a modernized case-management system. It is written now because the requirements for the replacement system are being set now: the Judicial Conference outlined an accelerated modernization in March 2026 and approved funding for it in June 2026, with early components already being piloted at six courts.¹²

The core argument: **most of what makes today's third-party ecosystem risky is not misbehavior — it is the absence of interfaces designed for delegation.** Every gap in the sanctioned surface pushes legal professionals toward workarounds the Judiciary itself has warned against. Closing those gaps is a security measure first and a convenience second.

2. The status quo pushes credentials in the wrong direction

The filing login is the attorney's signature under local rules. Yet in practice, attorneys do not operate CM/ECF alone: docketing departments, paralegals, and filing services do much of the work. Because the system has no concept of a delegated, limited-purpose credential, the working reality in firms of every size is shared attorney passwords — the exact practice the Administrative Office's July 10, 2023 memorandum and the court notices that followed it warned filers about, in the context of third-party service providers with access to sealed and restricted material.³

The 2023 guidance was right about the risk and the industry adjusted — major vendors stopped storing ECF credentials. But the underlying demand did not go away, because the work still has to be done by people other than the credential holder. A modernized system can resolve this correctly, at the platform layer, instead of leaving it to policy memoranda:

Requirement 1 — Delegated application credentials, distinct from the attorney’s signature credential. Scoped, revocable, per-application tokens (issued under an attorney’s or firm’s account) that can prepare and stage work, with the attorney-held signature credential required for the act of submission itself. OAuth-style delegation is the established pattern. The security benefit is direct: it replaces password sharing — invisible, unscoped, unrevocable — with delegation that is visible, scoped, and auditable by the courts.

Requirement 2 — Scoped tokens that cannot reach sealed or restricted material. Delegation must be narrower than the delegator’s own access. A token used by software should be issuable with an explicit ceiling: no sealed documents, no restricted-case content, regardless of what the underlying account may access. The August 2025 incident made concrete what is at stake in sealed-material exposure;⁴ scoped tokens turn “trust every integration with everything” into “trust each integration with exactly what it needs.”

3. Filing-interface requirements

These are the properties that determine whether filing automation is safe. Each one removes a class of error that today lands on clerks’ offices as correction work, or on attorneys as missed deadlines and duplicate fee charges.

Requirement 3 — Idempotent submission. A filing request must carry a client-generated identifier such that a retry after a timeout cannot docket twice. Today, a connection failure at the submit step leaves the filer guessing whether the entry exists — the cause of duplicate entries clerks must strike and duplicate fees that take weeks to reverse.

Requirement 4 — The event catalog as data. Each court’s event codes, categories, per-event document requirements, and fee consequences, published as a versioned, machine-readable feed (the court-lookup JSON/XML feeds are the right precedent⁵). Event selection is the highest-judgment step in docketing; mis-selection is the most common filing defect. A published catalog lets software present accurate choices to the human making that judgment — it does not replace the judgment.

Requirement 5 — Deterministic fee quoting. Given an event and case posture, the system should quote the fee before submission, in data. Fee surprises are a correction-queue burden for courts and a reconciliation burden for firms.

Requirement 6 — Structured filing results and NEFs. The confirmation returned at submission — and the NEF stream generally — as structured data (case, entry number, document identifiers, timestamps), not only formatted text. Every docketing operation in the country parses NEF emails with regular expressions today; every parser is a silent failure waiting to misfile a deadline.

Requirement 7 — Sandbox parity. A test environment that mirrors production interfaces and per-court configuration, available to any registered developer (the QA PACER environment is the right precedent). Integrations tested against production-shaped systems fail in production less; courts absorb fewer of those failures.

Requirement 8 — Attestation at the point of submission. The interface should make the human act explicit: submission requires the signature credential (Req. 1) and the system records what was displayed to the attesting filer. This gives courts a durable answer to “who signed this?” that is stronger, not weaker, than today’s shared-password reality.

4. Why interfaces beat prohibitions

The Judiciary has twice responded to third-party integration pressure with warnings — credential sharing (2023) and scripted retrieval load (the long-standing request that bulk automated queries run 6 p.m.–6 a.m. CT). Both warnings are reasonable, and both are stopgaps: they manage symptoms of missing interfaces. Integrations that identify themselves, authenticate with scoped tokens, and use supported endpoints can be rate-limited, audited, and — when they misbehave — individually revoked. Anonymous scripted traffic through user-facing pages can only be detected and blocked. A modernized system that offers the sanctioned path will find that most integrators prefer it; those that remain outside it become legitimately distinguishable.

The bankruptcy experience is the proof inside the Judiciary’s own record: Case Upload and the NextGen XML case-opening interfaces gave petition-preparation software a sanctioned channel, and structured bankruptcy filing became routine without credential-sharing controversy.⁶ District civil and criminal practice has no equivalent; that asymmetry, not any difference in demand, is why the gray-zone tooling concentrates there.

5. What I am asking for

1. That filing-interface requirements for the modernized system be gathered from docketing professionals as a distinct user class — the people who operate these systems at the highest frequency and see their failure modes first.
2. That delegated, scoped application credentials (Req. 1–2) be treated as a security deliverable of modernization, on equal footing with encryption and access control — because they are the structural fix for credential sharing.
3. A pointer to the right channel for this input, if it is not the EPA Public User Group or the developer mailbox.

I am glad to elaborate on any of this, with specifics from daily practice, at any level of technical depth that is useful.

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1. uscourts.gov, “Judges Outline Accelerated Modernization of Case Management System,” Mar. 10, 2026.
<https://www.uscourts.gov/data-news/judiciary-news/2026/03/10/judges-outline-accelerated-modernization-case-management-system> ↵
 2. uscourts.gov, “Judiciary Approves Funding for Case Management and Public Access Modernization,” June 26, 2026.
<https://www.uscourts.gov/data-news/judiciary-news/2026/06/26/judiciary-approves-funding-case-management-and-public-access-modernization> ↵
 3. See, e.g., D.P.R. Notice from the Clerk 23-06 (citing the AO’s July 10, 2023 memorandum); D.C. Cir., “CM/ECF — Access to Case Information and Documents by Third-Party Services” (2023). ↵
 4. Public reporting on the 2025 CM/ECF/PACER incident described potential exposure of sealed records. [Cite chosen carefully at send time; the Judiciary’s own March 2026 announcement references responding to “recent cyberattacks.”] ↵
 5. [pacer.uscourts.gov court CM/ECF lookup feeds \(data.json / data.xml\)](https://pacer.uscourts.gov/court/cm/ecf/lookup/feeds/data.json/data.xml). ↵
 6. PACER Developer Resources: Bankruptcy Case Upload; NextGen CM/ECF XML Case Opening and Docketing documentation. <https://pacer.uscourts.gov/file-case/developer-resources> ↵

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